

society & the arts PAKISTAN

While public protests mark Islamabad and Karachi, Lahore seems unaffected and immune, celebrating instead with a cultural extravaganza

■ By Nirmala Ravindran in Lahore

The Allama Iqbal International airport in Lahore is surprisingly calm, more so for the handful of Indians who have arrived on the weekly Delhi-Lahore Air-India flight. Hoping for some action or at least some visible sign that they have arrived in a country where Emergency has been imposed, it takes a couple of gun-totting security men to reassure the visiting tourists that everything is well in the country. Lahore is a surprise, and it starts at the airport—not because it's fancier or more hi-tech than any of India's (which it is), but because it is named after national poet Allama Iqbal, who was neither a religious, nor a political or a military leader. Referred to as the Paris of the East, Lahore's preoccupation with good things in life has been well-documented.

In the middle of an Emergency, what has captured the imagination of most of Lahore, is surprisingly not a political event, but a cultural one—the World Performing Arts Festival, the largest cultural event in South Asia. “Nothing has changed except for some foreign delegates backing out of the festival. Life is exactly the same,” says 23-year-old student volunteer Shoib Khan. It would be easy to agree with him, if one had not heard of many protests by students across Lahore.

The city, though, shows no signs of unrest—truckloads of armed police and protests can only be found inside university campuses. “All of us were part of the group that protested at the Punjab University. But we were protesting against the Jamiat's (Islamic Jamiat Talaba is the student wing of Jamaat-e-Islami) manhandling of Imran Khan and his subsequent arrest,” says Ambar Khan, 20, a media student at the university, who is vocal in her support

The people of Lahore still consider Musharraf their best bet for fighting fundamentalism

for Musharraf. “In this country, he's the best person for the job,” she says. “The Jamaat has been playing moral police in the universities, mixing religion and politics in academics. It's about time someone stopped it,” says Meher Mohammad, a business management student from the university.

There are many like her who feel safer with President Pervez Musharraf at the helm of affairs. “Lahoris are *shugalbaaz*, fun-loving people, and if we have someone who can't take a tough stand against the fundamentalists, our lives will change, and it certainly won't be for the better,” they say. Similar sentiments can be heard among the well-heeled of Lahore. “Nobody supports the Emergency, but I think Musharraf is the right man for the job. I don't want anyone in this country telling



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